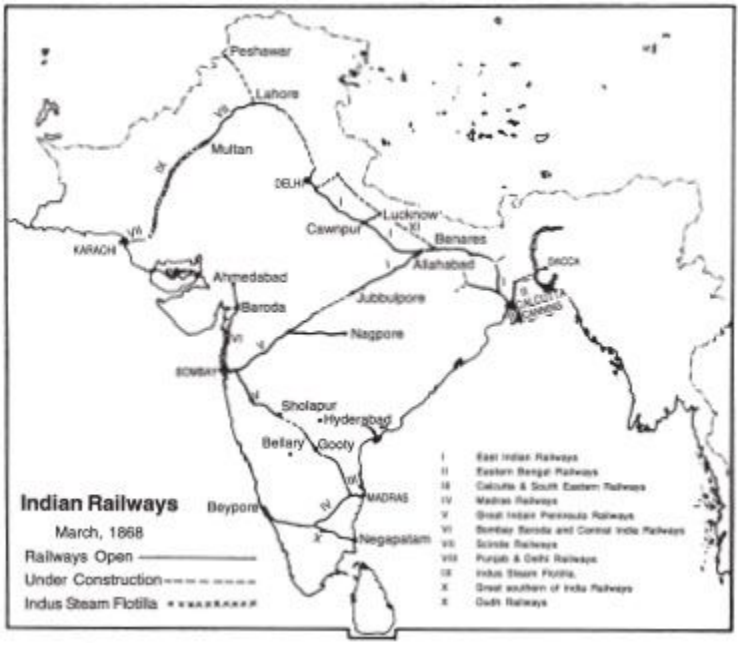


Map of the Indian Railways in 1868
(source *: Development of Indian Railways* by Nalinaksha Sanyal)

Given the available technology and the difficult terrain of central India, this was an impressive achievement. Yet, the pace of expansion accelerated in the 1870s with an average 468 miles (749 km) being added per year compared to 250 miles (400 km) in the previous period. [15] In 1878, 900 miles (1440 km) were added in a single year. This is incredible by any standard. By 1882, the country had a network that connected almost all major cities, and the Victorian engineers were feeling confident enough to build into the steep Himalayan hillsides in order to connect hill stations like Darjeeling and Simla.

Nonetheless, do not think of this as a seamless and integrated network. It was built in a hurry by different companies, agencies and princely states, using different standards and gauges, and with different objectives. This caused all kinds of operational inefficiencies that have not been entirely ironed out even in the twenty-first century. Still, the railway network dramatically re-ordered the economic geography of the country. Agricultural commodities could now be exported out from the hinterland